

A NEW APPROACH TO ENGLISH

Class - VIII



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BHUBANESWAR

A NEW APPROACH TO ENGLISH

Class - VIII

(Experimental Edition)

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Publisher

Department of School and Mass Education, Govt. of Odisha.

Year of Publication

2018

2019

Preparation:

English Language Teaching Institute, Odisha, Bhubaneswar
and

Directorate of Teacher Education and State Council of Educational
Research & Training, Odisha, Bhubaneswar

and

Odisha State Bureau of Textbook Preparation and Production, Bhubaneswar

Printing:

Textbook Production and Marketing, Odisha, Bhubaneswar

PREFACE

The Govt. of Odisha has decided to strengthen the teaching/learning of English in Odia medium Govt. Schools. The English Language Teaching Institute (ELTI) has already prepared a handbook on teaching English at the primary level. About sixty thousand teachers have been trained with the help of the book during 2016-2017 and each teacher has been provided with a copy of the book. Next, the ELTI with the help of SCERT and OPEPA has prepared this new series of textbooks in English from Class-III to Class- VIII based on sound principles of English Language Teaching and principles of pedagogy enshrined in NCF 2005. The books have been tried out with real learners and teachers. Necessary corrections have been made accordingly. I wish the teachers to read the introduction and notes for them provided in the books and teach the books accordingly. I also want the inspecting officials to go through the textbooks and supervise classes accordingly. The workbooks are carefully built into the textbooks. The teachers should use the books following a learner-centred approach and make learners do the tasks. They should correct learners' scripts and provide feedback. The Inspecting Officials are expected to supervise this regularly. Each textbook has also in-built tests to test the performance of both the learners and the teachers. Language indicators for each class are also provided at the end of the book for the guidance of both the teachers and the Inspecting Officials. This will help the parents to check the progress of their wards. Attempts are also being made to prepare similar text books in other subjects from the coming years based on these sound principles. But unfortunately, our attempts to strengthen teaching/learning through good textbooks failed to yield expected results due to widespread prevalence of cheap bazaar notes (Meaning Books) prepared only with the motives of commercial gains. These books provide cheap ready-made helps by working out the tasks/activities thereby preventing students from getting/developing skills and restrict them from the pleasure of doing the workbook tasks/activities on their own.

I am sure the new series will help our learners excel in all the four language skills of English --- Listening, Speaking, Reading and Writing. I thank the Editors and the Reviewers for their sincere efforts in preparing the excellent materials. I also thank Dr. Manmatha Kundu, the Academic Adviser and Mr. Indramani Tripathy, the Director of ELTI under whose academic and administrative guidance the books are prepared.

Any suggestions for the improvement of the book are welcome.

Commissioner-cum-Secretary
Department of School and Mass Education,
Govt. of Odisha

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INTRODUCTION

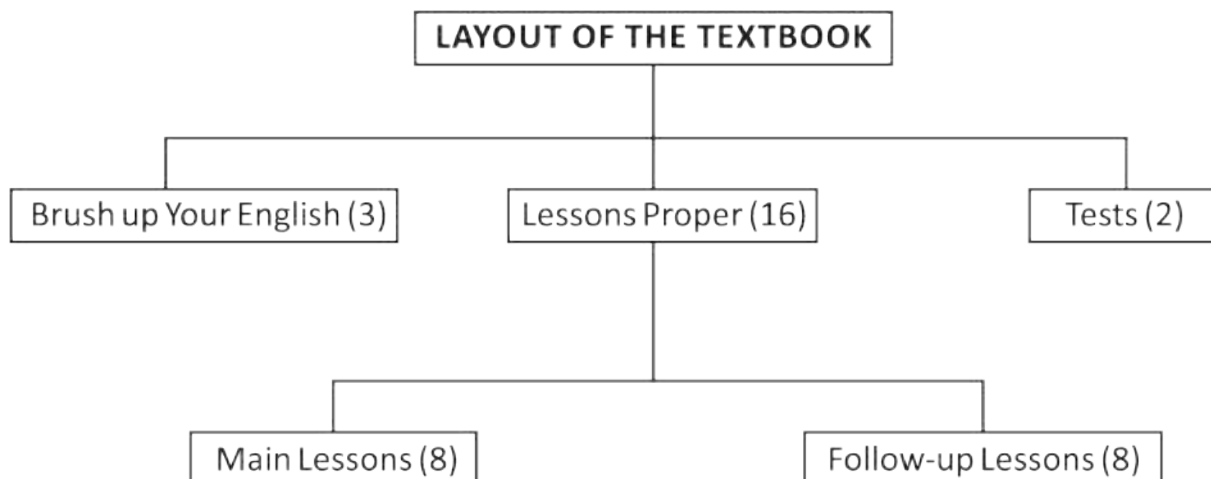
The Secret of Language Learning

Language is mostly learned through exposure and use in meaningful contexts. While the exposure to language is mainly done through listening and reading, use is done through speaking and writing. The more one listens to a language and reads in a language, the more s/he gets exposed to it. Exposure lays the foundation of a language and also the foundation for using the same. One cannot use (speak) the language unless one has sufficiently listened to it. One cannot write in the language unless one has widely read in the language. And both the exposure and use are to be done in meaningful contexts. What one listens and reads should be useful and interesting to him/her. Similarly, what one speaks and writes should also be interesting and useful for the user. In other words, all these are to be done in contexts and the user should be involved in activities. This is the secret behind learning any language.

What implication does this have for teaching English to our learners ? First, our learners should be sufficiently exposed to English through listening. In case of acquiring mother tongue, a child listens to the language for long to be able to speak. Listening to the language lays foundation for speaking. Do we provide enough exposure to English through listening before teaching our learners to speak and write in our Odia medium schools? Certainly not. We usually tend to start teaching of English from reading and writing. This is why our learners in our Odia medium schools face difficulties in learning English. Then how to overcome such difficulties ? In Order to do this we have to change the current trend of teaching English. Instead of beginning teaching of reading and writing, we should first develop the listening and speaking skills of our learners through storytelling and TPR (Total Physical Response) activities. The current primer of English (Class III) has, therefore , been revised and rewritten with enough pre-primer activities (Storytelling , rhymes , Known English words, TPR etc.) before learners learn to read and write.

The Textbook

The class VIII English textbook has also been revised and rewritten keeping in mind the development of listening and speaking skills of our learners along with the skills of reading and writing. In this book, there is enough listening and speaking exposure provided under each lesson mainly through interesting activities. The layout of the book is as follows :



The three “Brush up your English” lessons are simple and interesting. There are poems, rhymes and stories with very interesting mind-engaging activities. Hence, the name. The main purpose of this section is helping learners learn what they have not learned before. Currently, the skill of most learners is below their class level, more so in English classes. If their skills are not levelled up through right kind of learning, the main lessons will not work and the teacher will take recourse to reading aloud, explaining the text often in Odia and somehow complete the course as they were accustomed to do before. The tasks provided, therefore, are based on development of language skills. These three “Brush Up Your English” lessons serve as steps for reaching the lessons proper.

Lessons Proper

There are eight lessons – five prose pieces and three poems. These pieces are very carefully chosen, the main criteria of selection being simplicity (language) and interest value for the young learners of 12-13 years old. Each lesson has three major sections: pre-reading, while-reading and post-reading. The purpose of pre-reading is motivating the learners to read the text. The while-reading phase is devoted to interactive reading. The learner is taught to interact (communicate) with the writer through the text. This is the most important phase of the lesson. If this part is not properly done, the next phase, post-reading becomes futile. The post-reading phase is devoted to interesting learning activities based on the text. While doing these activities, the learner reads and rereads the text again and again on his/her own without being conscious of the fact that s/he is reading so many times. The activities become the main product and learning skills come as by-product.

Follow-up Lessons

These are, in fact, sub-lessons of the main lessons. There is mainly one sub-lesson under each main lesson. These Sub-lessons are called Follow-up Lessons. The sub-lessons are shorter and simpler than the main lessons. The themes are related to the themes of the main lessons. Compared to the main lessons, the sub-lessons are less controlled in the sense that both the teacher and learners are given freedom to work on their own, the primary purpose being development of autonomous learning. While the questions and activities are provided in the main lessons by the editors, teachers are encouraged to frame their own questions and activities for sub-lessons. Similarly, the learners are encouraged to read and comprehend the text and do the activities on their own with less guidance from the teachers. Learners are encouraged to self-correct and peer-correct their own writings. The other purpose of these sub-lessons is to relate the main text to their daily life experiences and use of English. In other words, they are discouraged to be textbook centric.

Tests

There are two tests, one after the 3rd lesson, and the other at the end. The tests are of 100 marks each. The tests intend to test the English language skills of the learners, the skills expected to be developed through these lessons. The test results will provide feedback to both the learners and the teachers- the learners will get the feedback whether they have developed the English language skills studying the text or not and the teacher will get the feedback whether they have been successful in helping the learners develop the expected English language skills or not. The tests will also help teachers frame similar small tests to be administered to students on a regular basis (formative tests).

Interlinking Materials and Methods

During the early phase of textbook writing, methods of teaching were not reflected in the textbook. So the teachers use their own ways of handling the text. Now, The material writers while preparing the textbook, visualized the method the teacher is to use to transact the material in the classroom. It is realized that method is more important than materials which is shown through the mathematical calculations: Good Materials + Bad Method= No result , Bad Materials+ Good Method= Some results. As a result, only persons having first-hand experience of teaching are asked to prepare material and trying out of material with real learners is made obligatory. In this book, we have linked the materials with the methods .The general approach suggested is learner-centred and activity –oriented approach with some specific techniques of teaching such as BS (Brainstorming), chain-drill, VMDT (Visual Memory Development Technique) and

MT (Mental Talk). A brief description of these four methods is provided in Appendix-II; Notes on Techniques.

The book is based on the good principles of education stated in NCF-2005. The method and approach used here are mostly learner-centred. The book takes into account this fact and makes provision for improving the skills of both the learners and teachers and the state of teaching learning, especially English. The book, in other words, provides a comprehensive treatment for the major faults of the current teaching /learning in general and the teaching / learning of English in particular.

Abbreviations used in the book :

- adj : Adjective
- BS : Brain Storming
- MCQs : Multiple Choice Questions
- MT : Mental Talk
- n : Noun
- phr : Pharse
- SGP : Sense Group Paragraph
- v : Verb
- VMDT : Visual Memory Development Technique